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### Corrections System Reform in the USA

The world is changing; everything is entirely different from how it was ruled decades ago. These changes are causing a lot of crises in many parts of society. As well, the U.S. correctional system is facing a crisis. Overcrowding, high recidivism rates, and the lack of adequate mental health care are just a few of the pressing issues that require immediate reform and attention. The need for a shift in focus—from punishment to rehabilitation—has never been more urgent; everyone deserves the help they need, everyone deserve a good life. Drawing from international models, such as Norway’s health-centered prison reform, this essay explores how the U.S. correctional system can be improved by prioritizing mental health and well-being, reducing recidivism, and fostering reintegration into society. We all have to question ourselves about “What needs to be changed in the U.S. correctional systems to reduce the amount of crime?”, “How can we help people with mental health problems in prison successfully reintegrate into society while adding additional resources to the corrections system?”. In this essay will be discussed ways to reduce recidivism and promote rehabilitation, the U.S. correctional system must prioritize mental health care and adopt international best practices that emphasize the well-being of both inmates and correctional staff, in order to achieve these goals.

One of the primary challenges faced by the U.S. correctional system is the high prevalence of mental health disorders among incarcerated individuals. According to the National Alliance on Mental Illness (NAMI), about two in five people in U.S. prisons have a history of mental illness. The incarceration of individuals with mental health conditions without providing appropriate care only exacerbates their issues and increases the likelihood of recidivism. “ 37% in state and federal prisons and 44% held in local jails have mental health issues”, according to the information in the Mental Health Treatment While Incarcerated | NAMI: National Alliance on Mental Illness. Countries like Norway have implemented a unique approach to their correctional systems that prioritizes the well-being of inmates while emphasizing rehabilitation over traditional punitive measures. This system creates a supportive environment that encourages personal growth and skill development rather than simply enforcing punishment. A significant insight gained from the U.S.-Norway exchange program is the understanding that prison reform should be grounded in principles of health and humanity. This means recognizing inmates as individuals with potential for change and recovery, which ultimately benefits society by reducing recidivism rates and facilitating reintegration into the community. Countries can foster a more humane and effective correctional system by centering reform efforts on compassionate treatment and rehabilitation. As the Role of a US-Norway Exchange in Placing Health and Well-Being at the Center of US Prison Reform.” reports, “A pre-post self-assessment of the training revealed gains in knowledge and skills, including in motivational interviewing, de-escalation, risk assessment, understanding incarceration’s negative effects, and reducing use of solitary confinement; 40% said the experience was “life-changing.” The US correctional system needs improvements to better the mental health of both penitentiary staff and inmates, as the staff’s mental health directly affects that of the inmates.

The article by Ahalt et al., titled "Role of a US-Norway Exchange in Placing Health and Well-Being at the Center of U.S. Prison Reform," provides an in-depth analysis of how the principles of Norway's rehabilitation-focused prison system can significantly improve mental health outcomes in U.S. correctional facilities. Norway's approach centers on rehabilitation rather than punishment, prioritizing mental health care for inmates and ensuring the well-being of prison staff. This system promotes a more humane environment that fosters personal growth and supports the overall mental health of those incarcerated. Key elements of the Norwegian model include an emphasis on providing comprehensive mental health services, engaging inmates in meaningful activities, and maintaining a supportive atmosphere among staff and inmates. Conversely, the U.S. prison system tends to emphasize punitive measures, often leading to inadequate mental health resources and high levels of stress among both inmates and correctional staff. This punitive focus frequently results in practices like solitary confinement, which can exacerbate mental health issues and contribute to a cycle of distress and reoffending. By integrating successful practices from Norway, such as significantly reducing the use of solitary confinement and implementing structured wellness programs for staff, the U.S. has the opportunity to create a more conducive environment for rehabilitation. These changes could not only improve the mental and emotional well-being of inmates but also alleviate staff burnout. Adopting these strategies could lead to a transformative shift in how the U.S. approaches prison reform, focusing on rehabilitation and promoting healthier, more supportive environments for everyone involved.

Education and research are also essential components of criminal justice reform. According to Frost's article "Research Training for Criminal Justice Reform," comprehensive research training is critical for the next generation of criminal justice professionals. Teaching students

how to conduct research and use what they find can help improve the correctional system. This article highlights that change should come from informed choices and evidence-based practices. Other sources in this research also support this idea. Education should focus on criminal justice policies, mental health care, and rehabilitation strategies.

Reducing repeat offenses is an important goal for reforming prisons in the United States. The Department of Justice report, “Prison Reform: Reducing Recidivism by Strengthening the Federal Bureau of Prisons,” highlights the need for solid inmate reentry programs. These programs often offer job training, educational classes, and mental health support. They help inmates gain the skills and assistance they need to return to society successfully. Research in the report shows that inmates who take part in educational programs while in prison are 43% less likely to re-offend compared to those who do not. This shows how effective education can be and emphasizes the need for proper resources and support during incarceration. By investing in these programs, prisons can help inmates build essential skills, find a sense of purpose, and create a stable, law-abiding life after release. These efforts lead to safer communities and a fairer society by breaking the cycle of crime and punishment.

Many sources highlight the need for community involvement in reforming the prison system and support services. In their article, “Creating Spaces for Change: Engaging Civil Society to Harness Change in Criminal Justice Practice,” McCulloch and Smith discuss how civil society can drive justice reforms. They believe civil society can advocate for responses to crime that are more humane and effective. The authors stress that reforms should aim to improve existing institutions to make them fairer and more efficient. Community participation is a vital part of this improvement. Involving local people in reform helps ensure the criminal justice system meets their needs and concerns. McCulloch and Smith also point out that restorative justice and

community-based programs can effectively address the root causes of crime. These methods focus on healing and rehabilitation rather than just punishment. They aim to help individuals reintegrate into society and reduce repeat offenses. Criminal justice systems can create safer communities and promote a fairer society by prioritizing long-term rehabilitation and social reintegration. In the journal of probation, one of the most important messages stated:

"Considered through these lenses, our reflections on the project outcomes and impacts suggest that we have much to learn and do. The project revealed considerable appetite and capacity for innovation, some consensus regarding the nature of change needed, and evidence of multiple political, academic, professional, civic and citizen initiatives orientated towards that, albeit often with limited connect" (p240).

As individuals with mental health issues are disproportionately represented in the criminal justice system, providing them with appropriate treatment is essential for successful reintegration into society. NAMI's article, "Mental Health Treatment While Incarcerated," highlights the importance of addressing mental health disorders in correctional settings. Without proper treatment, many individuals are more likely to reoffend. Mental health care is important for both personal well-being and public safety. Providing inmates with access to mental health services can help reduce repeat offenses and improve outcomes for people leaving prison. NAMI (National Alliance on Mental Illness) explains the strong link between mental health problems and involvement in the criminal justice system. "People with mental health conditions are overrepresented in our nation's jails and prisons — with many individuals becoming justice-involved due to a lack of adequate community mental health services. " Many individuals enter the criminal justice system mainly because their mental health issues go untreated. If we properly address these issues, everyone can benefit—individuals and society. When people are in jail,

they usually get little to no mental health treatment. As a result, when they leave, they often lack the skills and support needed to manage their conditions. This lack of care fails to help individuals recover and puts them and the community at risk, as they may return to harmful behaviors. To change this situation, we need to improve mental health resources and ensure people get the treatment they deserve. Creating community programs can help stop many individuals from becoming part of the justice system, leading to a healthier society.

To improve the U.S. correctional system, we need a clear plan focused on three main areas: mental health support, education, and job training. We should involve community members in this process since their experiences can help create better policies. One effective model is Norway's correctional system, which prioritizes mental health care for inmates. It addresses issues like addiction, trauma, and psychological disorders. Norway shows that focusing on inmates' health can lead to positive results by providing counseling and treatment. Instead of treating incarceration just as punishment, we should focus on rehabilitation. Studies show that inmates receiving education and job training are less likely to re-offend after release. Providing skills and a sense of purpose helps them reintegrate into society, which benefits everyone. Now is the time for these changes. Suppose policymakers commit to using evidence-based strategies and encourage open discussions in local communities. In that case, we can build a correctional system that promotes safety, reduces repeat offenses, and improves the lives of former inmates and society.

We must take immediate action to ensure that everyone has the opportunity to lead a better life and improve their circumstances. It is crucial to recognize that all individuals are human beings deserving of dignity and respect. Everyone should have access to the fundamental resources necessary for a fulfilling life, such as quality education, clean water, and mental healthcare.

Regardless of where we live, we must work towards creating a society where these essential needs are met. By doing so, we can help lift communities out of poverty and create a more equitable world for all. We must take immediate action to ensure that everyone has the opportunity to lead a better life and improve their circumstances. It is crucial to recognize that all individuals are human beings deserving of dignity and respect. Everyone should have access to the fundamental resources necessary for a fulfilling life, such as quality education, healthcare, clean water, and adequate housing. Regardless of where we live, we must work towards creating a society where these essential needs are met. By doing so, we can help lift communities out of poverty and create a more equitable world for all.

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